



Leading the charge: Current Indian national captain Salima Tete (front) will be central to Soorma's attacking efforts, while veteran Savita Punia will be crucial in goal. GETTY IMAGES

along with the retired Rupinder Pal Singh. These are all undisputed talents, but their consistency remains in question. This team is perhaps the most diverse in terms of players' nationalities, and there is hope that the various styles and temperaments will mesh well, and quickly. Pirmin Blaak, guarding the goal, will be the standout star.

Women: Surprisingly, despite having a triple-Olympic champion and bonafide legend like Eva de Goede, Indian defender Udit Duhan is the most talked-about player on the team. Kolkata went all out to secure Udit, making her the highest-paid player at the auctions, and hopes the gamble pays off.

While her calibre is undeniable, it meant compromising elsewhere, particularly in foreign player bids. Nonetheless, Bengal managed to sign Belgian striker Ambre Ballenghien and Dutch playmaker Eva. Between Eva and Sushila Chanu, there is enough experience in

midfield, while Vandana Katariya, Lalremsiami, and Beauty Dung Dung will be crucial upfront.

Kalinga Lancers

Men: The team secured its star player at dirt cheap price. Belgium's Alexander Hendrickx, a world-class drag-flicker, defender, and leader, is expected to score the bulk of goals for the only team remaining from the previous version of the league, even retaining its support staff but under new ownership.

Another key player is his national teammate Arthur van Doren, perhaps the only player to win both the Rising Star and Player of the Year in the same year (2017). Their partnership in defence will play a big role in keeping other teams at bay. It will also be a chance for Krishan Pathak to finally step out of Sreejesh's shadow against world-class attacks.

SHRACHI RARH BENGAL TIGERS WENT ALL OUT TO SECURE UDITA DUHAN, MAKING HER THE HIGHEST-PAID PLAYER AT THE AUCTIONS

Odisha Warriors

Women: Former India coach Janneke Schopman's familiarity with Indian and European players was evident as she persisted in acquiring Yibbi Jansen.

The Dutch drag-flicker was the top scorer at the Paris Olympics and a key reason for Netherlands' gold medal win.

Schopman would hope she does the same here. Her knowledge of Indian players means she went big on youngsters including Rituja Pisal, Annu, and Anjali Barwa, without neglecting experience, bringing in Freeke Moes and Neha Goyal to create one of the most balanced sides.